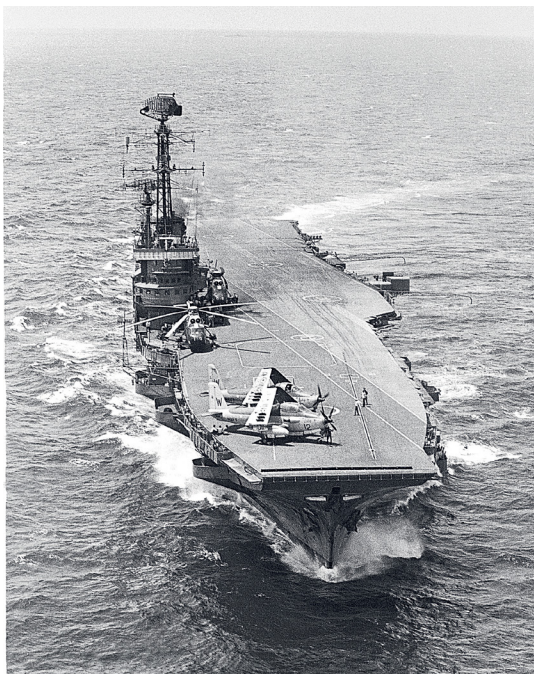


Bombing of the Governor's House

(1971 Indo-Pak war)

The 1971 war was the Indian military's finest hour, liberating Bangladesh in two weeks and taking 93,000 Pakistani soldiers prisoners. According to the official history of the 1971 India-Pakistan War, the task allotted to Eastern Command was to "destroy the bulk of the Pakistan forces in the Eastern Theatre and occupy the major portion of East Pakistan, including the entry ports of Chittagong and Chalna-Khulna". Dhaka was not mentioned as a military objective as it was considered beyond the Eastern Command's capability. By December 9, 4 Corps had secured the eastern bank of Meghna and completed the task allotted to it. However, Lt Gen. Sagat Singh, the Corps Commander, ordered a heli-lift of troops across the Meghna. Between December 9 and 11, the IAF airlifted the entire 311 Brigade, flying more than 110 sorties and landing them barely 60 km from Dhaka. On December 14, Indian artillery fired its first salvo into the heart of Dhaka. Combined with the crossing of Meghna, the Tangail airdrop completely dislocated the defence of Dhaka. 2 Para, airdropped north of Tangail, captured the Poongli bridge and cut off Pakistan's 93 Infantry Brigade that was rushing south to reinforce Dhaka. In considerable measure, the Meghna heli-lift and the Tangail airdrop created the conditions for the complete surrender of the Pakistan Army in East Bengal. The final blow was struck by four MiG 21s and four Hunters on December 14, which attacked the Dhaka Governor's House with rockets, ripping the massive roof off the main hall. The East Pakistan Governor, Dr A.M. Malik was so rattled after the incident that he resigned with a "shaking ballpoint pen", hastening the surrender.



BHAWAN SINGH

Naval Blockade of East Pakistan

(1971 Indo-Pak war)

At the start of the war, the Indian Navy established an effective blockade of East Pakistan, trapping Pakistan's naval assets in their ports. On December 3, Pakistani submarine PNS *Ghazi* was sunk while attempting to lay mines off the Visakhapatnam coast. From December 4, Seahawk and Alize aircraft from India's aircraft carrier INS *Vikrant* carried out devastating attacks on Chittagong, Cox's Bazar, Chalna and Khulna. On December 12, The Fleet Commander reported to the Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Eastern Naval Command: "There is no merchant ship...in Chittagong harbour and approaches which has not been struck and incapacitated." The successful blockade, destruction of ports, and prevention of any escape from East Pakistan contributed significantly to the final outcome of the war. Although India's borders remained unchanged after the war, the birth of Bangladesh created a completely different strategic geography for India and its security calculus.